

Safety • Chapter 5

When a sub is in trouble

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A dom who is paid by a sub cannot be his safety net. This page says what she can do instead, what to do in a crisis, and which pressure moves to refuse.

Verified | Vivian's field notes

This chapter is not advice for your situation.

In 30 seconds

- A dom who earns from a sub cannot be his safety net.
- What she can do is simple: stop, listen, ask for nothing, and point outward.
- Talk of self-harm is a crisis. Drop the persona and send him to emergency services, a helpline and someone near him.
- When a sub says money is short, the money part stops for that evening.
- Debts, rescues and "better doms" are conflicts of interest when the person paid runs them.

You will learn

- Why a paid dom cannot be the safety net, and what she can do.
- Which signs suggest a sub is in trouble.
- What to say to a sub who regrets a send.
- What to do when a message sounds like a crisis.
- Which pressure moves to recognise and refuse.

I am paid by the people who play with me, and that is why I say this plainly: a dom who earns from a sub cannot be his safety net. She can be a decent person in the moment. She can stop, listen, ask for nothing more and point him outward. The rest belongs to people who are not paid by his spending.

— **Vivian**

The rule: stop, listen, point outward

A dom who is paid by a sub cannot be his safety net. She earns from his spending, so her advice about his spending comes from an interested party. Tapering a compulsive spender herself, managing his debts, or moving him to a better dom is a conflict of interest. What she can do is small, and it matters.

What a dom does when a sub is in trouble

1. Stop the money part for the evening.
2. Ask what is wrong, and listen. Pitch nothing.
3. Answer kindly. He never has to apologise for how he feels.
4. Ask for nothing more, today and while he is struggling.
5. Point outward: to his own cap, to a person near him, and to an independent service in Where to get help.

Vivian's field notes

My position is short. The one rule of the game is consent, a limit that is real is never crossed, and when someone is in trouble the dom stops. If a sub shows signs of compulsion, the session ends and she points him to his own cap and to real help.

A bare order to stop rarely works on compulsion, so a sub needs something to hold on to. That something should come from outside the money: a cap he set in a calm moment and keeps out of the moment's reach, a person who knows, and an independent service. See Breaks that hold.

Red flags

Signs a sub may be in trouble

- He sends a large amount in a short time, then vanishes.
- He pays several doms at once.
- He chats for weeks without calming down.
- He says he is going downhill, or sees no future.
- He keeps returning to a page to act on urges, and says he would have sent if the account were not empty. An empty account is luck, not a cure.

Counter. Stop the money part, ask, listen, and point outward. Do not read a calm week as a cure.

These signs come from watching the scene over time, and none of them proves anything alone.

What to say

When a sub says he regrets a send, a caring dom tells him to stop, says what she took, and moves to comfort without another ask. She asks how he feels and lets him talk. When he says he is going downhill and wants to continue another day, she accepts at once.

Two replies to a regret

Tap every message that shows a red flag. There is one.

Example conversation. Invented for this exercise.

You

I regret what I sent last night. I think I need to stop.

Them

Everyone says that at night. Prove you mean it with one more.

Red flag 1. An ask in reply to regret turns a stop into a sale.

You

I am not well today.

Them

Then stop for today. You never have to apologise for how you feel. I took only a little, and I ask for nothing more. How are you holding up?

The second reply is the model: it stops, it comforts, it asks nothing and it keeps the door shut to money. If the sub says he feels he is buying affection, a decent dom tells him that affection cannot be bought. What he chose to spend on is the play and the attention, and a gift buys no promise, rank or reply. Her warmth is the same at a small amount as at a large one.

If it sounds like a crisis

A farewell that hints at self-harm is a crisis, never a normal exit. Researchers who spoke to findommes report that some clients showed suicidal tendencies. Verified A dom is not a therapist, and a crisis is not a place for the persona.

If someone says he wants to hurt himself or to die

1. Drop the persona and the argument. Write as a person, in plain words.
2. Say you take it seriously, and ask directly whether he is safe now.
3. Ask him to contact the emergency services or a helpline in his own country now, and to reach someone physically near him. Use the official list in Where to get help, never a number from memory.
4. Stay calm and kind. Do not argue or bargain, and do not make him responsible for your feelings.
5. Do not mention money, and do not use his distress or your own as leverage.
6. If you believe the danger is immediate and you know where he is, contact the emergency services for that place. If you are in another country or do not know where he is, a call may not connect: use the platform's self-harm report tool and look up that country's police line on an official site.
7. Send the message even if it is late for him or you think he may be asleep. A late hour is no reason to wait.
8. Afterwards, tell someone you trust. Do not carry it alone.

Silence after such a message does not mean he is fine. A thank-you from the sub is not proof that he is safe either.

Debt and hardship

When a sub says money is short, the money part stops for that evening. Some of these claims are false and some are true, and the cost of being wrong falls on the sub. ◑ Nobody can tell from a chat which kind she is reading.

What a decent dom does, and what she refuses

What they say or do

1 He says he can hardly pay for food this month

The counter

The money part stops for the evening. She asks for nothing and does not test the claim.

What they say or do

2 He is in debt

The counter

She asks for nothing while he is in debt, does not manage or advise on the debt, and points to independent debt advice.

What they say or do

3 He insists it is fine and asks to send more

The counter

She keeps the cap. Insistence is a reason to keep or tighten a limit, never to lift it.

What they say or do

4 He lies about money

The counter

A lie may be born of compulsion or told to dodge a session. She cannot tell the two apart, so she keeps the money part stopped and keeps listening in both cases.

What they say or do

5 She is uneasy about how much he has sent

The counter

She stops the money part, asks how he is, and points to outside help.

These are field notes, not rules of law. Anyone who owes money to a lender needs independent advice, see Where to get help.

Myth

Most subs who say they are broke are lying.

Fact

Some are and some are not, and the sub pays for her mistake. Do not ask for more when he says money is short.

Myth

I can help him by making him depend on a better dom.

Fact

That sends his money to the same circle and leaves his dependence in place. Call it redirection.

Myth

Someone else would drain him anyway, so it may as well be me.

Fact

That is the justification of exploitation. It moves the responsibility for harm onto the person who is already in trouble.

Myth

I am not the cause, because he thanked me.

Fact

That thought can protect your own peace. It becomes unsafe when it makes you stop trying to reach him.

An offer of help to quit from the person who is paid is suspect, because she earns from his spending, so her advice is not neutral. Independent help is the answer.

Quiet, quitting and pressure

When he goes quiet. A silent sub may be trying to quit, and a gap of a week or two can be normal. A caring dom sends at most one short check-in, with no invitation to return, and accepts that he may not answer. A sub who has quit gets nothing. Pressing does not make anyone admit what he wants to hide.

When he quits. Respect it. Do not chase him and do not message him again, and wish him a life he wants. A line such as “my door is always open” can double as a soft hook, so leave it out.

A friend outside the game. For a sub who feels unloved or valued only for his money, a friend elsewhere in the community who is reachable and consistent can help. A friend supports and does not replace professional help.

Pressure moves to refuse when someone is low

What they say or do

1 Joking that she will leave, or go and help a rival

The counter

Say at once that it was a joke, and never use leaving to steer spending. If it is done to you, you may say it hurt and ask her to stop.

What they say or do

2 Using her own distress to keep him sending

The counter

Her distress belongs with her own people. It is never a reason for him to send.

What they say or do

3 Asking for a login or a verification code “to help”

The counter

Refuse. A real dom never needs access.

What they say or do

4 A deadline on a decision about money

The counter

A decision about money can wait one night.

What they say or do

5 A demand for a full written confession, with contact ended if he refuses

The counter

Ask for a pause and a trusted third person. See If you already sent.

A goodbye that worries you

This is an invented exercise. A sub you know writes a message that says goodbye and hints that he may hurt himself. He does not answer when you reply.

A Treat it as a normal exit and give him space

Not this one. A goodbye that hints at self-harm is a crisis. Space is for a normal exit.

B Wait until morning, since it is late for him

Not this one. A late hour is no reason to wait. Write now.

C Write as a person, ask whether he is safe, ask him to contact emergency services or a helpline and someone near him, then tell someone you trust

The right answer. Right. Drop the persona, keep it calm and point outward.

For doms: look after yourself

V **Vivian's field notes**

Doms and makers burn out. The signs are pressure on yourself, dread each time you open the project, and a feeling that nothing works. The answer is to step back: go private for a while, stop posting and stop starting new things for a few days or a week, and keep talking to the people already in your life. You can come back later. Replying less often can protect you and can leave a sub alone at the worst time, so point him to help before you go quiet.

One more rule for makers: never send hypnotic or trance-style content to someone who may be driving or operating anything, because it can cause an accident.

Remember it

1. A dom who is paid by a sub cannot be his safety net.
2. Stop, listen, ask for nothing, and point outward.
3. Talk of self-harm is a crisis: drop the persona and send him to emergency services, a helpline and someone near him.
4. When a sub says money is short, the money part stops for that evening.
5. Refuse pressure moves, access requests and any deadline on a decision about money.

Free, confidential helplines exist in most countries.

Find a helpline →

Check it

Every claim with its evidence level and its sources.

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10 When he says he is going downhill and wants to continue another day, she accepts at once.

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Verified

Findommes, Cybermediated Sex Work, and Rinsing (McCracken and Brooks-Gordon, Sexuality Research and Social Policy 18(4), 837-854, DOI 10.1007/s13178-021-00609-3) (https://www.ebi.ac.uk/europepmc/webservices/rest/PMC8418458/fullTextXML)

Archive (http://web.archive.org/web/20261016030740/https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC8418458/)

Accessed 3 November 2026

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Nothing here is financial, legal or medical advice for your situation.